Mauja and *Saadhe Naal Rahoge te Aish Karoge*. The British left us some wonderful precepts, one being to 'work hard and play hard'.

Later in the evening, we experienced another wonder being unravelled in our midst. All of a sudden there was silence and everyone was asked to gather in the ante-room of the mess. A specially designed stand to hold my much-valued military baton was brought into the room, along with my baton, and presented to me. My deputy military assistant, Colonel P.J.S. Pannu from 22nd Maratha Light Infantry (Hyderabadis), had observed the care and pride with which I always carried my baton since it bore the crests of all the units and formations that I had commanded in my over four decades of service. He felt that this baton should rest on a special stand painstakingly designed by him and which, on its base, bore the names of all the officers of my secretariat. It was a superlative gesture, notwithstanding my once casual personal expression to Colonel Pannu that my baton and medals, along with many other trophies, should appropriately be housed in the Maratha Light Infantry Centre Museum. The baton finds a pride of place in my home today.

As we emerged from the officers' mess, another surprise package greeted us! Our car was nowhere to be seen. A 'two in hand' ceremonial horse carriage or buggy was waiting in the porch instead. The carriage was accompanied by a mounted escort of five cavalry troopers in full ceremonial attire from the Indian Army's only horse-mounted regiment, the 61st Cavalry, of which I had had the privilege of being the colonel commandant in my capacity as the chief of the army staff. In all, there were seven horses – an auspicious symbolism! We were escorted to the carriage by my aides-de-camp and instead of the usual farewells, everyone, including the graceful ladies present, broke into a choral rendition of 'For he's a jolly good fellow.' Our pleas to end this affectionate display fell upon deaf ears till we reached our destination, 20 Mandir Marg, a distance of almost one-and-a-quarter kilometres.

Now it was my opportunity to turn the tables on my team. I declared that this was not to be the end of the evening and that I would not let them depart without a 'thank you' drink. This